

DECODED EXPLAINED

1st August, 2026

Western Ghats Conservation With Science and Dialogue

Western Ghats conservation with science and dialogue

The Western Ghats, spanning six coastal States of India, are internationally recognised for their rich biodiversity. They contain 39 biodiversity hotspot areas, including national parks, reserved forests, and wildlife sanctuaries declared World Heritage Sites (WHS) by UNESCO in 2012. To protect this natural heritage, the Western Ghats Ecology Expert Panel (WGEEP) was constituted in 2010 under the chairmanship of ecologist, academic, and writer Madhav Gadgil. Its report recommended declaring 142 talukas covering 44 districts in the entire Western Ghats into Ecologically Sensitive Area (ESA), while sub-dividing it into three Ecologically Sensitive Zones (ESZ). Such a declaration would regulate human activities to protect fragile ecosystems and, once notified under the Environment Protection Act, 1986, would provide legal protection.

The ESA journey

Following strong local and political opposition in the States concerned to the WGEEP recommendations, the central government constituted a high-level working group headed by Krishnaswamy Kasturirangan in 2012 to review them. The group limited restrictions on economic activities and livelihoods to ecologically sensitive natural landscapes, reducing the area covered to only 37% of the Western Ghats.

Based on this recalibrated report, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEF&CC) issued the first draft notification in 2014. Since the matter remained unresolved, the Ministry constituted an expert panel headed by former Director General of Forests Sanjay Kumar in 2022 to examine the concerns raised by the stakeholder States. Following the expert panel's deliberations, Gujarat and Goa appear to have agreed to the finalisation of the ESA notification, while Maharashtra has sought a fresh review.

Discussions between the Centre and other States, including Karnataka, Kerala, and Tamil



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The Ecologically Sensitive Area debate highlights the need for balanced, inclusive conservation approaches

Nadu, are ongoing. A “phased rollout” or “State-wise finalisation” is possible after the inclusion of this clause in the 2024 draft notification.

Between 2015 and 2026, five draft notifications were issued as the Centre and States did not reach a consensus. Following the expiry of the last notification, in July 2026, the Ministry has extended the expert panel's tenure by another year.

The case of Karnataka

Karnataka has 10 districts in the Western Ghats, with 23.4% of the State's population residing there. Around 20,668 square kilometres have been identified for ESA declaration. Regardless of the government's political affiliation, the State has consistently opposed the proposal, citing its potential impact on agriculture, plantations, mining, and infrastructure development.

A study by this writer covered villages located in the proximity of 10 WHS across four districts – Chikkamagaluru, Kodagu, Shivamogga, and Udupi – and three other important sites in Uttara Kannada and Udupi, including the Kali Tiger Reserve, Mundigekere Bird Sanctuary (five acres and a breeding ground for cattle egrets in Sirsi), and Mookambika Wildlife Sanctuary. The study highlighted local perspectives on livelihoods and conservation efforts.

In villages adjoining the Kali Tiger Reserve and Kudremukh National Park, some residents reported accepting or considering rehabilitation packages. Those opposing relocation felt that they might eventually have to follow due to declining village populations and the resulting threat to village life. Even villages with granted forest rights have faced challenges due to restrictions on minor forest produce collection and agricultural practices. Concerns were also raised over the rejection of forest rights claims by non-tribals with long-standing residence, including in a village (at least 150 years) near the

Balahalli Reserved Forest. Meanwhile, local officials and some communities supported regulating environmentally harmful activities such as stone quarrying and unplanned tourism projects, including proposals for forest ropeways.

With specific reference to the notifications, it must be noted that local communities faced similar restrictions whenever these areas were declared protected zones, even before the WGEEP was constituted. Many residents believe that buffer zones extend 10 kilometres from core areas and fear possible eviction from their lands. Stakeholders across the study districts unanimously expressed concerns that reliance on satellite imagery for identifying ESA areas was unfair, as they were convinced that it could not distinguish plantation crops such as arecanut, shade-grown coffee, rubber, and coconut from forest cover. They also raised concerns that no committees had physically visited their villages.

In this context, Karnataka's case requires an empathetic approach that addresses genuine stakeholder concerns before a final decision is taken.

Protecting indigenous communities

In the broader context, the Union government's decision to proceed with the ESA notification for the Western Ghats reflects political will to protect ecology and biodiversity. Conservation efforts cannot be indefinitely delayed as it will result in States losing their control in such areas; ecological systems transcend administrative boundaries.

More importantly, ESA should include indigenous communities living deep within forests, as they naturally follow conservation principles and maintain a sacred, sustainable relationship with the environment despite challenging conditions. Their presence serves as a bridge between forests and mainstream society, while their absence risks the loss of biocultural diversity.

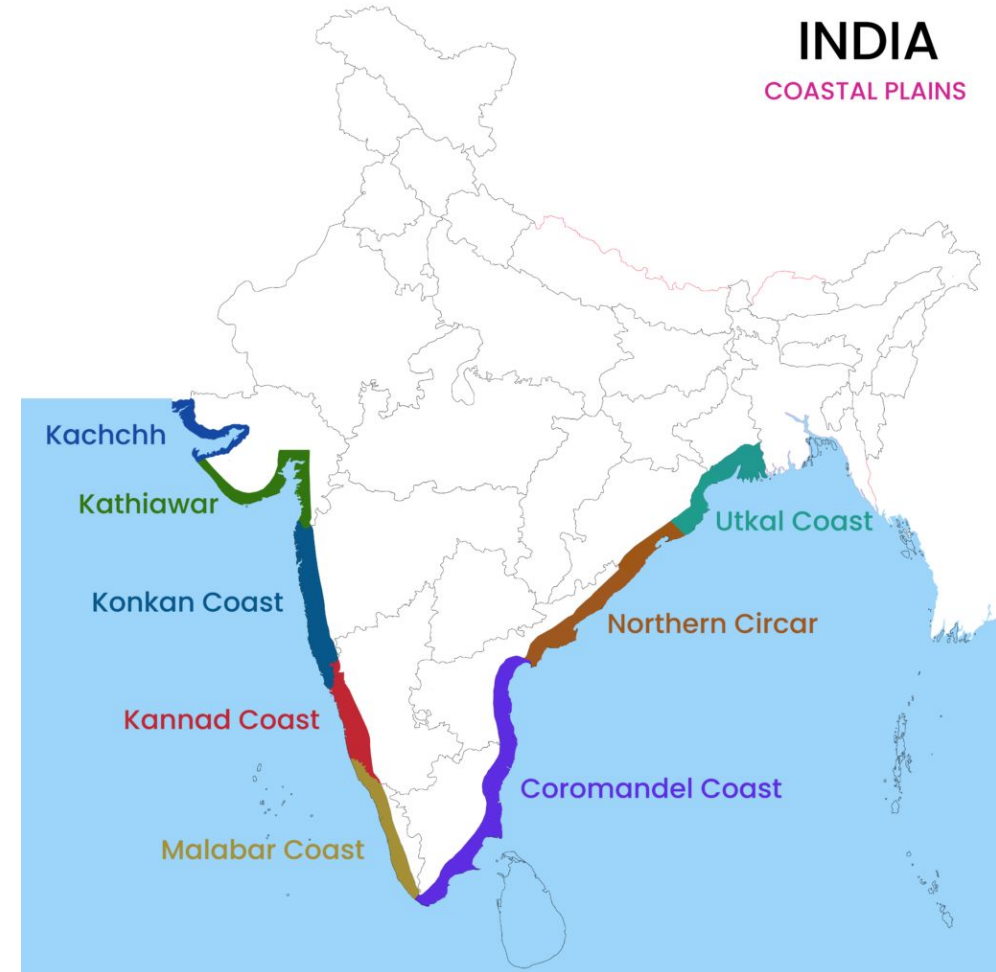
Western Ghats Conservation With Science and Dialogue

The Western Ghats, also known as the Sahyadri Hills, are well known for their rich and unique assemblage of flora and fauna.

The range is called Sahyadri in northern Maharashtra and Sahya Parvatham in Kerala.

The foothill region east of the Ghats in Maharashtra is known as Desh, while the eastern foothills of central Karnataka state is known as Malanadu.

The peak of Anamudi in Kerala is the highest peak in the Western Ghats, as well as the highest peak in India outside the Himalayas



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Significance of Western Ghats

Climate:

The mountains of the Western Ghats influence the Indian monsoon weather patterns that mediate the warm tropical climate of the region. The Ghats act as a key barrier, intercepting the rain-laden monsoon winds that blow from the south-west during late summer.

Hydrological:

The Western Ghats feeds a large number of perennial rivers of peninsular India including the three major eastward-flowing rivers Godavari, Krishna, and Kaveri.

Biodiversity:

Western Ghats along with its geographical extension in the wet zone of Sri Lanka are now also considered one of the eight, hottest hotspots' of biodiversity. The Western Ghats contain exceptional levels of plant and animal diversity and endemism.

Ecological

The Western Ghats play a significant and important ecological function in sequestration of atmospheric CO₂ and hence have an important role in climate change.

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Economic

The Western Ghats are rich in iron, manganese and bauxite ores.

The forests of Western Ghats are an important source of timber and support a large number of forest-based industries such as paper, plywood, poly-fibres and matchwood.

In parts of their ranges Pepper and cardamom, which are native to the evergreen forests of the Western Ghats have been taken up as plantation crops on a large scale.

Other large scale plantations include tea, coffee, oil palm and rubber.

Home to Indigenous Tribes:

The indigenous people of the Western Ghats, including the Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups

The communities have been deriving sustenance from the forest by collecting non-timber forest produce (NTFP).

Tourism and Pilgrimage Centre:

There are a number of tourist centres that have sprung up in the Western Ghats; example: Ooty, Thekkady WS etc.

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Threats to Western Ghats

Deforestation:

Conversion of forest land into agricultural land or for commercial purposes like tourism, illegal logging for timber have had significant negative effects on biodiversity.

Mining:

The mining activities have grown rapidly especially in Goa and often in violation of all laws, resulting in serious environmental damage and social disruption.

Sand mining has emerged as a major threat in Kerala.

Unsustainable mining has increased vulnerability to landslides, damaged water sources and agriculture, thus negatively affected the livelihoods of the people living in those areas

Plantations:

Agroforestry systems in the Western Ghats are today dominated by tea, coffee, rubber and monocultures of various species, including the recently introduced oil palm.

Encroachment by Human Settlements:

Human settlements where legal and/or traditional rights of land ownership occur both within and outside protected areas all across the Western Ghats and represent a significant landscape level threat.

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Extraction of Forest Produce:

Human communities living within and adjacent to protected areas in the Western Ghats are often dependent on extraction of NTFPs to meet a diversity of subsistence and commercial needs.

With rising population and changing consumption patterns, sustainability of NTFP is a critical issue.

Livestock Grazing: Livestock grazing within and bordering protected areas by high densities of livestock (cattle and goats) is a serious problem causing habitat degradation across the Western Ghats.

Human-wildlife Conflict:

Given that the Western Ghats exists within an intensely human-dominated landscape, human-wildlife conflicts are a common phenomenon.

Hunting:

Illegal local hunting driven by tradition or demand for wild meat is pervasive across the Western Ghats.

Hydropower Projects:

Large dam projects in Western Ghats have resulted in environmental and social disruption despite cost benefit analyses and environmental impact assessments being done by the government and companies

Climate Change:

The changes in land use and deforestation have led to big variations in the duration and intensity of rainfalls.

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Committees for Western Ghats:

Gadgil Committee (2011): Also known as the Western Ghats Ecology Expert Panel (WGEEP), it recommended that all of the Western Ghats be declared as the Ecological Sensitive Areas (ESA) with only limited development allowed in graded zones.

Kasturirangan Committee (2013): It sought to balance the development and environment protection in contrast to the system proposed by the Gadgil report.

The Kasturirangan committee recommended that instead of the total area of Western Ghats, only 37% of the total area should be brought under ESA and a complete ban on mining, quarrying and sand mining be imposed in ESA.

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What is Eco-Sensitive Zone?

The Eco Sensitive Zones are envisaged as a cushion or shock absorbers for protected areas. They are supposed to act as the transition zones from areas of high protection to less protection.

They are notified by the Ministry of Environment, Forests and Climate Change, Government of India around Protected Areas, National Parks and Wildlife Sanctuaries.

They are like an ecotone- the transition between two biological communities or ecosystems, and it is crucial for the protection of protected areas like wildlife sanctuaries and forests.

Its aim is to reduce the impact of human intervention in the core protected area.

Western Ghats Conservation With Science and Dialogue

The National Wildlife Action Plan (2002-2016) of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) stipulated that state governments should declare land falling within 10 km of the boundaries of national parks and wildlife sanctuaries as eco-fragile zones or Eco-Sensitive Zones (ESZs) under the Environmental (Protection) Act, 1986.

10-km rule is implemented as a general principle

Activities Around ESZs:

Prohibited Activities: Commercial mining, saw mills, industries causing pollution (air, water, soil, noise etc), establishment of major hydroelectric projects (HEP), commercial use of wood.

Regulated Activities: Felling of trees, establishment of hotels and resorts, commercial use of natural water, erection of electrical cables, drastic change of agriculture system, e.g., adoption of heavy technology, pesticides etc, widening of roads.

Permitted Activities: Ongoing agricultural or horticultural practices, rainwater harvesting, organic farming, use of renewable energy sources, adoption of green technology for all activities.

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With reference to 'Eco-Sensitive Zones', which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. Eco-Sensitive Zones are the areas that are declared under the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972
2. The purpose of the declaration of Eco-Sensitive Zones is to prohibit all kinds of human activities in those zones except agriculture.

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

This question was previously asked in
UPSC Civil Services (Prelims)
Exam GS Official Paper-I (Held...

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1. 1 only
2. 2 only
3. Both 1 and 2
4. Neither 1 nor 2

'Gadgil Committee Report' and 'Kasturirangan Committee Report', sometimes seen in the news, are related to

This question was previously asked in
Official UPSC Civil Services Exam
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1. Constitutional reforms
2. Ganga Action Plan
3. Linking of rivers
4. Protection of Western Ghats

Cabinet Okays ₹84,084-cr. Samudra Manthan for Offshore Exploration

Cabinet okays ₹84,084-cr. Samudra Manthan for offshore exploration

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

To boost India's offshore exploration efforts, the Union Cabinet approved an outlay of ₹84,084 crore to the Union Petroleum Ministry's National Offshore Exploration Scheme Samudra Manthan.

The corpus is to be utilised until FY2030-31. The overall outlay is categorised into four key components the most important of which relate to drilling 60 deepwater exploration wells for which the Cabinet has allocated ₹43,200 crore.

This is inclusive of the government of up to 50% of eligible drilling cost or ₹675 crore per well.

The other component relates to offshore data acquisition which carries an outlay of ₹28,534 crore.

Development of common offshore infrastruc-



Well oiled plan: The scheme aims at catalysing reserves of over 600 MMTOE. (For representational purpose only) GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK

ture hubs to facilitate commercialisation of discoveries, which would be accounting for an outlay of ₹10,000 crore.

Finally, the establishment of oil and gas manufacturing and services zones - seeking to promote domestic manufacturing and localisation of critical equipment and services - tabulate an outlay of ₹2,000 crore.

Overall, the Union government's flagship scheme for offshore exploration aims at catalysing reserves of more than 600 million metric tonnes of oil equivalent (MMTOE).

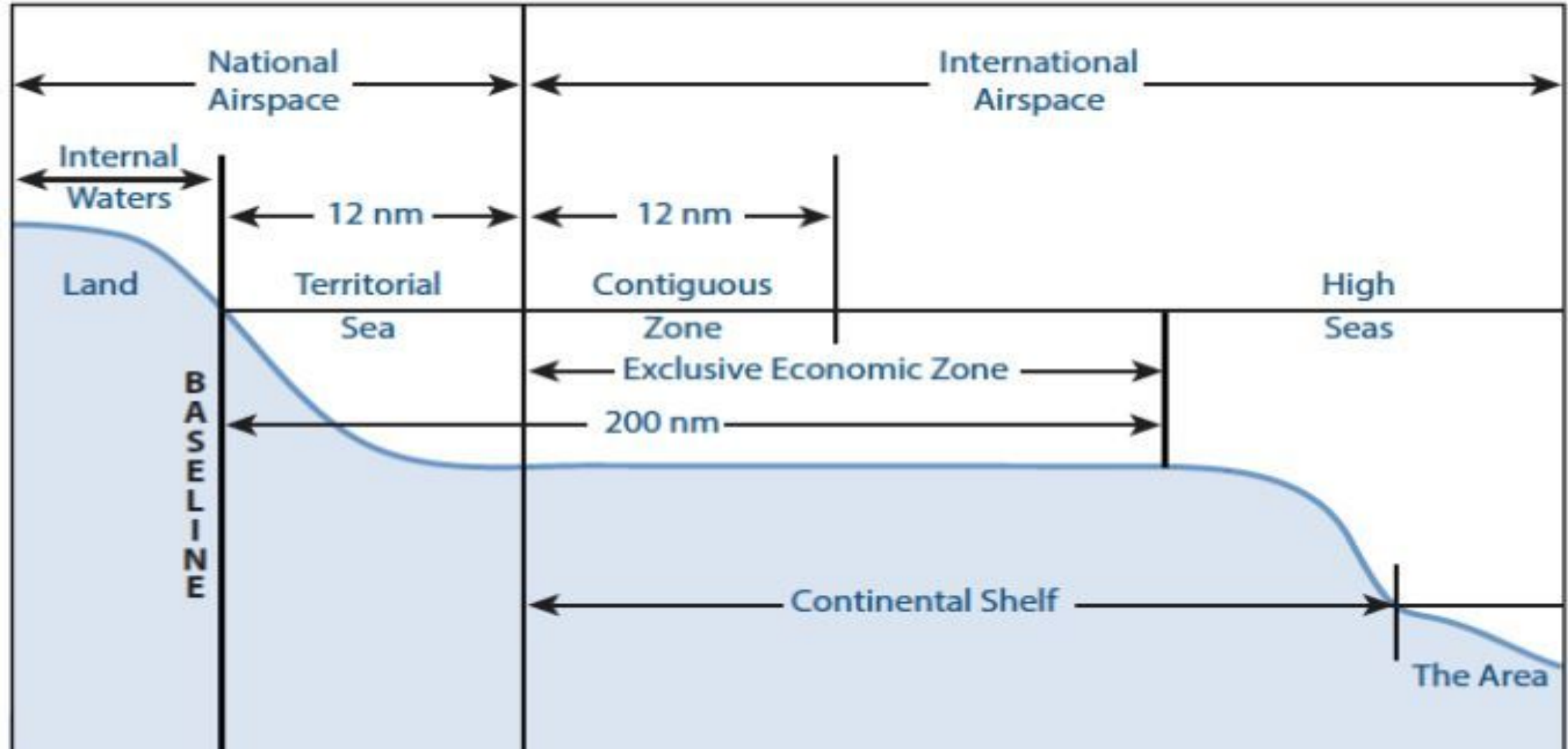
Stimulating investments
It envisages to "stimulate significant investments across the exploration and production value chain, creating long-term oppor-

tunities for industry, innovation and economic growth."

Essentially, with hydrocarbon exploration being a capital-intensive activity with long gestation period but essential for a country's domestic energy security, the scheme seeks to reorient growth into this sector (via offshore exploration) to overcome difficulties from ageing oil and gas fields.

Reflecting on the announcement, Rajnish Gupta, partner for tax and economic policy, EY India held, "Investments in large-scale seismic data acquisition and drilling of exploratory well in deep and ultra deep waters will reduce geological uncertainty and de-risk exploration and lay the foundation for future discoveries. Good results can catalyse greater private investments in the sector."

Cabinet Okays ₹84,084-cr. Samudra Manthan for Offshore Exploration



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The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), 1982 divides marine areas into five main zones: Internal Waters, Territorial Sea, Contiguous Zone, Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ), and the High Seas.

It is the only international convention setting out a framework for state jurisdiction in maritime spaces, giving each zone a different legal status.

- **Territorial Sea:** extends up to 12 nautical miles from the baseline. Coastal states hold sovereignty and jurisdiction over the surface, seabed, subsoil, and airspace.
- **Contiguous Zone:** extends up to 24 nautical miles from the baseline, an intermediary zone between the territorial sea and the high seas; unlike the territorial sea, it gives jurisdiction only over the ocean's surface and floor, not air and space.
- **Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ):** extends up to 200 nautical miles from the baseline, giving the coastal state sovereign rights to explore, exploit, conserve, and manage living and non-living resources of the seabed and subsoil, and to carry out activities like energy production from water, currents, and wind.
- **High Seas:** the ocean surface and water column beyond the EEZ, considered "the common heritage of all mankind" and beyond any national jurisdiction.

Cabinet Okays ₹84,084-cr. Samudra Manthan for Offshore Exploration

Deep-sea mining is the process of retrieving mineral deposits from the deep seabed – the ocean below 200m.

There are three types of such mining,

Taking deposit-rich polymetallic nodules off the ocean floor

Mining massive seafloor sulfide deposits

Stripping cobalt crusts from rock.

These nodules, deposits and crusts contain materials, such as nickel, rare earths, cobalt and more, that are needed for batteries and other materials used in tapping Renewable Energy and also for everyday technology like cellphones and computers.

Companies and governments view these as strategically important resources that will be needed as onshore reserves are depleted and demand continues to rise.

Cabinet Okays ₹84,084-cr. Samudra Manthan for Offshore Exploration

Deep Ocean Mission is led by the Ministry of Earth Sciences and aims to develop deep-sea technologies for sustainable extraction of minerals, energy, and freshwater from the oceans.

Deep Ocean Mission (DOM) is an ambitious initiative to explore and harness the vast resources of the country's 7,517 km coastline and 2.37 million sq km Exclusive Economic Zone.

Deep Ocean Mission is led by the Ministry of Earth Science.

Manned Submersible - 'Samudrayaan': MATSYA 6000 is an indigenously developed manned submersible capable of carrying 3 people to a depth of 6000 metres under the sea for deep ocean exploration and facilitating close observation and on-site analysis of deep-sea features.

Cabinet Okays ₹84,084-cr. Samudra Manthan for Offshore Exploration

With this technology, India will join the elite group of nations—USA, Russia, China, France, and Japan—capable of conducting crewed deep-sea missions.

Remotely Operated Vehicles (ROVs): Unmanned ROVs will also be deployed for wide-area seafloor mapping, exploration and sampling.

India holds a 75,000 sq. km area in the Central Indian Ocean and an additional 10,000 sq. km (26° S) granted by the United Nations International Seabed Authority (ISA under UNCLOS

United Nations named the 2021-2030 decade as the ‘Decade of Ocean Science for Sustainable Development’.

Cabinet Okays ₹84,084-cr. Samudra Manthan for Offshore Exploration

Question 2: Consider the following statements: (UPSC Prelims 2021)

1. The Global Ocean Commission grants licences for seabed exploration and mining in international waters.
2. India has received licences for seabed mineral exploration in international waters.
3. "Rare earth minerals" are present on the seafloor in international waters.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Cabinet Okays ₹84,084-cr. Samudra Manthan for Offshore Exploration

Question 1: With reference to the United Nations Convention on the Law of Sea, consider the following statements: **(UPSC Prelims 2022)**

1. A coastal state has the right to establish the breadth of its territorial sea up to a limit not exceeding 12 nautical miles, measured from a baseline determined in accordance with the convention.
2. Ships of all states, whether coastal or land-locked, enjoy the right of innocent passage through the territorial sea.
3. The Exclusive Economic Zone shall not extend beyond 200 nautical miles from the baseline from which the breadth of the territorial sea is measured.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Cabinet Okays ₹84,084-cr. Samudra Manthan for Offshore Exploration

Which of the following statements with regard to India's Deep Ocean Mission is/are correct?

1. It was launched by the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Government of India.
2. Matsya-6000 has been designed to carry 3 people for deep sea exploration.
3. Samudrayaan is a project under this mission.

Select the answer using the code given below:

[Select an option to attempt](#)

☐ A 1 only

☐ B 2 and 3 only

☐ C 1 and 2 only

☐ D 1, 2 and 3

A Healthy Tax: The Government Must Act to Tax Foods High in Fat, Sugar, and Salt

A healthy tax

The government must act to tax foods high in fat, sugar, and salt

India, which has a long history of addressing the challenges of undernutrition, has to pivot to attack the curious phenomenon of over-nutrition that evolving lifestyles have now laid at its door. The recent National Family Health Survey data showed that in India, while stunting and undernutrition continue to be cause for concern, despite some gains, the sharp rise in adult overweight and obesity, besides diet-related metabolic conditions, cannot be ignored any more. Two unrelated developments have advanced the question of unhealthy diets in very pointed suggestions that would nudge consumers to make the right choices. First, a Parliamentary Standing Committee has recommended mandatory front-of-pack nutrition labelling indicating whether packaged food products are high in sugar, and second, a national consortium has advised the government to levy a health tax on high fat, salt and sugar foods, and enforce stricter regulations on their advertisements. The Standing Committee on Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution also made a recommendation to include the sugar content in baby foods, attacking the excess sugar consumption issue right where it begins. The consortium on adolescent nutrition, which goes by the practical name Let's Fix Our Food, is led by the Indian Council of Medical Research-National Institute of Nutrition (ICMR-NIN), and comprising several other prominent institutions in India and abroad, has recommended that the government ensure a healthier school food environment, stricter regulation of marketing of unhealthy food, and front-of-pack nutrition labelling. These efforts will be among the steps to tackle the rising burden of obesity and diet-related non communicable diseases that require a comprehensive strategy helmed by the government.

According to the World Health Organization, since 2017, at least 133 countries have increased or introduced a new health tax. A "junk food law" came into force in Colombia in 2023, to tackle the high consumption of packaged foods. An additional tax on such foods began at 10%, rose to 15% the next year and touched 20% the subsequent year. Norway, Hungary, Denmark, Bermuda, Dominica, St. Vincent and the Grenadines, and the Navajo Nation (U.S.), have also specifically implemented taxes on unprocessed sugar and sugar-added foods. With the ICMR-NIN report indicating that over 17 million children and adolescents are affected by obesity, and that this number can cross 27 million by 2030, there cannot be a better time to act on these suggestions that will go a long way in educating the consumer to make healthy food choices.

A Healthy Tax: The Government Must Act to Tax Foods High in Fat, Sugar, and Salt

● The Context

Recent National Family Health Survey data showed that while stunting and undernutrition continue to be a cause for concern, the sharp rise in adult overweight and obesity, besides diet-related metabolic conditions, cannot be ignored any more

● Two Key Developments

- First, a Parliamentary Standing Committee has recommended mandatory front-of-pack nutrition labelling indicating whether packaged food products are high in sugar, and has also recommended including sugar content disclosure in baby foods
- Second, a national consortium called Let's Fix Our Food, led by the ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition, has advised the government to levy a health tax on high fat, salt, and sugar foods, and enforce stricter regulations on their advertisements

● Global Precedent

- According to the WHO, since 2017, at least 133 countries have increased or introduced a new health tax; a 'junk food law' came into force in Colombia in 2023, with an additional tax on packaged foods beginning at 10%, rising to 15% the next year, and touching 20% the subsequent year
- Norway, Hungary, Denmark, Bermuda, Dominica, St. Vincent and the Grenadines, and the Navajo Nation in the US have also specifically implemented taxes on unprocessed sugar and sugar-added foods

Cabinet Approves Scheme to Promote 'Floating' Solar Plants

Cabinet approves scheme to promote 'floating' solar plants

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

The Union Cabinet on Friday approved the Pradhan Mantri Surya Sarovar Yojana, a ₹5,070-crore scheme aimed at accelerating floating solar power by providing central financial assistance of up to ₹1 crore per MW for projects installed on reservoirs and other water bodies.

The programme targets 5,000 MW of floating solar capacity by 2030-31.

The scheme, to be implemented by the Solar Energy Corporation of India, comes at a time when India has about 0.7 GW of installed floating solar capacity despite an estimated potential of 102 GW.

Projects receiving support under the scheme will have to include battery energy storage equivalent to at least two hours, amounting to 10,000 MWh across the programme, to help States meet peak demand and reduce the curtailment of renewable power during periods of excess generation.

India's flagship project, the Omkareshwar floating solar park, located on the Narmada in Madhya Pradesh's Khandwa district is the country's largest at 278 MW, with plans to scale to 600 MW output. However,



The programme targets 5,000 MW of floating solar capacity by 2030-31.

it doesn't have onsite battery storage.

Officials said the financial support was intended to "nudge" the industry to develop an alternative stream of solar capacity. Solar development in India has remained concentrated in Rajasthan and Gujarat because of their vast tracts of inexpensive land and high solar radiation.

Reservoir-based projects are expected to "diversify" installations, particularly in States with large water bodies but limited land availability.

The policy is also designed to address two of the biggest constraints facing ground-mounted solar projects: acquiring large contiguous parcels of land and the rising costs associated with rehabilitation and resettlement.

Cabinet Approves Scheme to Promote 'Floating' Solar Plants

Pradhan Mantri Surya Sarovar Yojana (PM-SSY)

The PM-SSY is a Central Sector Scheme to promote the development of Floating Solar Photovoltaic (FSPV) Projects integrated with Energy Storage Systems (ESS).

The scheme has a financial allocation of Rs. 5,070 crore to develop 5,000 MW of FSPV capacity between FY 2026-27 and FY 2030-31.

To ensure grid stability, the projects are required to include co-located Energy Storage Systems with a minimum storage capacity of two hours (totaling 10,000 MWh across the scheme).

Land-Neutral Technology: Unlike ground-mounted solar, floating solar eliminates competition for agricultural land and habitation, making it ideal for large-scale deployment.

The Omkareshwar Floating Solar Park on the Narmada River (Madhya Pradesh) is India's largest operational project at 278 MW, with a planned expansion to 600 MW. It is the largest floating solar park in India.

S. Sreejith, Suresh Rajpurohit Get Promoted to DGP Rank

S. Sreejith, Suresh Rajpurohit get promoted to DGP rank

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The State government promoted Suresh Rajpurohit and S. Sreejith to the rank of Director General of Police (DGP) on Friday. The promotions were implemented shortly after the retirement of Director General of Kerala Fire and Rescue Services Nitin Agrawal.

Notably, Mr. Rajpurohit's promotion has been made on a proforma basis since he is presently away on Central deputation. Mr. Sreejith, who is presently posted as Director General of Prisons and Correctional Services, will continue to hold the position.

Home department sources indicated that more transfers are in the offing to fill the post of Managing Director of the Ker-



S. Sreejith and Suresh Rajpurohit.

ala State Beverages Corporation, which has remained vacant for nearly a week since the suspension of Additional Director General of Police M.R. Ajith Kumar, and the position of the Director General of Kerala Fire and Rescue Services.

Speaking at his farewell parade held at the SAP ground in Thiruvananthapuram, Mr. Agrawal

called Kerala Police a model force for the country. He said the experience and training he received in the State had greatly contributed to his professional career and enabled him to serve more effectively in different assignments.

A 1989-batch IPS officer, Mr. Agrawal is the recipient of several prestigious honours, including the President's Police Medal.

S. Sreejith, Suresh Rajpurohit Get Promoted to DGP Rank

The Director General of Police (DGPs) are the highest-ranking police officers in states and union territories.

Supreme Court Directives in Prakash Singh Case (2006)

DGPs must be appointed through a merit-based and transparent process.

They must have a minimum tenure of at least two years, to prevent arbitrary transfers influenced by political pressures.

State governments are required to consult the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) before appointing a DGP.

The Court rejected the practice of appointing "Acting DGPs" to ensure stable and permanent leadership.

Process

Sending List of Eligible Officers to UPSC : State governments must send a list of eligible IPS officers to the UPSC for consideration.

Eligibility Criteria : Officers must have a minimum of 25 years of service.

Should hold the rank of Additional Director General (ADG) or equivalent.

UPSC's Role : Selection committee, chaired by the UPSC Chairman, evaluates the candidates.

The UPSC prepares a panel of three officers deemed most suitable for the DGP position.

Shortlisted names are sent back to the respective state government.

The state government appoint one of the officers as the DGP.

Spain's PM Blames Trafficking Gangs as 60,000 Cross Into Ceuta in a Day

Spain's PM blames trafficking gangs as 60,000 cross into Ceuta in a day

At least 57 migrants died during the crossing attempt; Sanchez calls the breach a violation of Spain's territorial integrity; Spain's Interior Ministry says half of the migrants had already returned to Morocco; EU leader terms it 'unacceptable'

Associated Press
CEUTA

About 60,000 migrants crossed from Morocco into Spain's tiny Ceuta territory in the past 24 hours, Ceuta's President said on Friday, a figure that is equivalent to 70% of the population of the city in North Africa. At least 57 migrants died on the journey.

But roughly half of the people who made the crossing soon made their way back voluntarily, the Spanish government said, after the sudden arrival of so many migrants triggered chaos and a humanitarian crisis.



Massive influx: Members of Moroccan security forces gather at the site of clashes on the Morocco-Spain border, on Friday. AFP

"The situation that Ceuta is going through is absolutely unsustainable," Juan Jesus Vivas told the media.

Spain's Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez visited Ceuta and condemned the

breach which he described as "a violation of Spain's territorial integrity".

Mr. Sanchez blamed human smugglers for the crisis, saying they "deceive so many young people, and

ultimately lead many of them to their deaths – whether in the ocean or, as in this case, at Spain's border in the city of Ceuta".

Spain's Interior Ministry, which had initially refused to share estimates from the border, released its own figures shortly after Mr. Vivas spoke, estimating that some 50,000 people had crossed from Morocco since Thursday.

The border crisis boiled over with security forces clashing with migrants on the Moroccan side of the border. Video footage of the border early on Friday showed hundreds of migrants gathered on a hill overlooking Ceuta being dispersed with tear gas by

Moroccan forces, while others continued to swim to the Spanish territory.

Rachid Sbihi, who leads a local workers association representing Civil Guard officers, described the situation as a "serious humanitarian crisis," saying thousands of migrants, including unaccompanied children, were left sleeping in parks and on pavements, while others roamed the streets.

European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen said the "images coming from Ceuta are unacceptable".

"We cannot allow anyone to come to our Union without abiding by our rules," she said on Friday.



Spain's PM Blames Trafficking Gangs as 60,000 Cross Into Ceuta in a Day

Spain

Spain is located on the Iberian Peninsula in southwestern Europe

Bordering Countries:

It shares its borders with Portugal (to the west),

France and Andorra (to the northeast), and

The British Overseas Territory of Gibraltar (to the south).

Morocco: Via the autonomous cities of Ceuta and Melilla on the North African coast

Maritime borders: It is bounded by the Mediterranean Sea (to the southeast and east), the Bay of Biscay (to the north), and the Atlantic Ocean (to the northwest and southwest).

Capital City: Madrid.

The Pyrenees Mountains form a natural barrier between Spain and France.

The Meseta Central is a vast interior plateau, dominating the central part of Spain.

Archipelagos: Includes the Balearic Islands in the Mediterranean and the volcanic Canary Islands in the Atlantic.



Spain's PM Blames Trafficking Gangs as 60,000 Cross Into Ceuta in a Day

Catalonia (Catalunya) Separatist Movement

The Catalonia (Catalunya) separatist movement is a political movement in northeastern Spain seeking greater autonomy or independence based on Catalonia's distinct language, culture, and historical identity. The movement gained momentum due to perceived fiscal imbalances, demands for self-governance, and memories of repression under the Franco dictatorship (1939–1975). Its defining moment came in 2017, when the Catalan government held an independence referendum that was declared unconstitutional by Spain, leading Madrid to impose direct rule under Article 155. Unlike a classical insurgency, the movement has remained largely non-violent, pursuing its objectives through elections, legal challenges, and mass public demonstrations.



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Basque Country Insurgency

The Basque Country insurgency was a violent ethno-nationalist separatist movement led mainly by ETA (Euskadi Ta Askatasuna), which sought an independent Basque homeland spanning northern Spain and parts of southwestern France. Emerging in 1959 during the Franco dictatorship, ETA employed bombings, assassinations, kidnappings, and other militant tactics for decades, resulting in more than 800 deaths. Following Spain's democratic transition, greater regional autonomy, effective counter-terrorism cooperation between Spain and France, and declining public support for violence, ETA declared a permanent ceasefire in 2011 and formally dissolved in 2018, marking the end of one of Europe's longest-running separatist insurgencies.



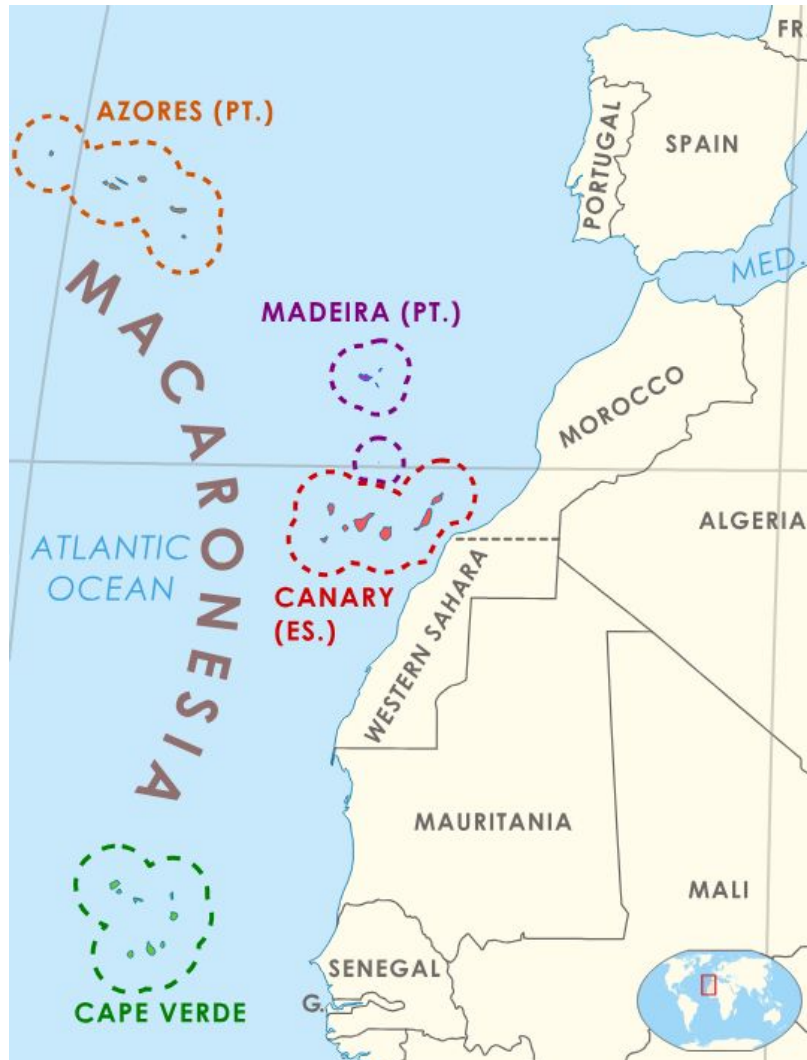
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Canary Islands

Canary Islands are an archipelago located off the northwest coast of Africa in the Macaronesia region of the North Atlantic Ocean. Read more about Canary Islands, Location, Area, Capital, Latest News.... Read more at



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Macronesia consists of

Azores (Portugal),

Madeira (Portugal) ,

Canary Islands (Spain)

Cape Verde (Independent Country

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UPSC Prelims 2018 Question:

Consider the following pairs:

Sl. No.	Regions sometimes mentioned in the news		Country
1	Catalonia	:	Spain
2	Crimea	:	Hungary
3	Mindanao	:	Phillipines
4	Oromia	:	Nigeria

Which of the pair given above are correctly matched?

1. 1, 2 and 3

2. 3 and 4 only

3. 1 and 3 only

4. 2 and 4 only

Consider the following pairs:

	<i>Region often mentioned in the news</i>	<i>Country</i>
1	Anatolia	Turkey
2	Amhara	Ethiopia
3	Cabo Delgado	Spain
4	Catalonia	Italy

How many pairs given above are correctly matched?

This question was previously asked in

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1. Only one pair

2. Only two pairs

3. Only three pairs

4. All four pairs

Where are the Balearic Islands located?

- a. Mediterranean Sea
- b. Black Sea
- c. Baltic Sea
- d. North Sea

UPSC Prelims PYQ 2005

Thank You